Circles Brainstorming: Community Ideas & Perspectives

Introduction

This report analyzes the themes, ideas, and perspectives shared during community brainstorming sessions about Circles, a universal income protocol that enables participants to create their own currency backed by social trust. Rather than offering implementation guidance, this document focuses on understanding what resonated with community members and what possibilities they envisioned.

Key Themes & Ideas

Reimagining Value & Exchange

A central theme throughout the discussions was the potential for Circles to create alternative understandings of value and exchange. Community members expressed excitement about how Circles might recognize contributions that fall outside traditional economic frameworks.

> "It's just a social agreement, and we can form other social agreements. And yeah, it's a small tool to start doing that." - Jose

Participants were drawn to how Circles challenges fundamental assumptions about money:

1. **Self-determined value**: Rather than accepting externally imposed valuations, communities can decide for themselves what their currency is worth
2. **Recognition of invisible work**: Several participants noted the potential to acknowledge care work, knowledge sharing, and environmental contributions that typically go unrecognized
3. **Decoupling from extraction**: Interest in creating currency systems that aren't tied to extractive economic models

> "Art is something that we are not really paying as much attention to as a society... I feel lucky if we can find some way to have a way for artists and people who are more into creative things to produce what they want and for people to be able to...give them their UBI or donate to them." - Delos

The concept of creating circular value flows was particularly compelling to several participants, who saw potential for building reinforcing systems of exchange rather than linear transactions.

> "We need to have a lot of these circular value flows because sometimes it takes a long time for them to flow." - Jose

Building Community Bridges

Many participants were excited about Circles' potential to connect different communities, both digitally and physically.

> "We have the best impact of Web3 when we connect with communities from all over the world in intercultural exchange and beyond the barriers of language." - Jose

This perspective was particularly emphasized by participants from Venezuela, who saw potential for creating economic systems that could function in regions where traditional currency has become unreliable or inaccessible.

> "This is still a tool for people who have money to play with, but how does this fit into a context where people don't have money to experiment with but are actually looking for infrastructure or opportunities?" - Jose

The trust-based mechanism of Circles was seen as potentially valuable for creating connections across different types of communities:

1. **Geographic communities**: Linking local economies across different regions
2. **Interest communities**: Connecting people with shared artistic or political interests
3. **Practice communities**: Uniting people engaged in similar work or activities

The ability to have different communities define their own values while maintaining interoperability was described as a powerful feature.

Nuanced Recognition Systems

Participants were intrigued by the possibility of creating currencies that express different types of value beyond just financial worth.

> "Having something else with different values basis, preferably customizable... enables us to express value in different ways." - Charlie

The concept of having complementary currencies that could capture different types of contribution resonated with several participants:

> "I've been trying to bang the drum for us having some sort of alternate currency that transmits social value. In my opinion, we should call it roses, but who knows? Yeah, and some kind of not just bread but roses too, kind of thing, like multiple ways to show value that aren't strictly financial but can interact with the financial system." - rathermercurial

This idea of multiple, interconnected but distinct value systems represented a significant departure from how participants typically thought about currencies and tokens.

Community-Inspired Use Cases

Supporting Artists & Creators

Musicians and artists envisioned specific ways they might use Circles to sustain their work outside traditional funding models.

Collaborative Artist Circles

Jose, a musician from Venezuela, described a model of artist cooperation:

> "Each week you rotate who is the artist that has the spotlight from these 18, and then the other 17 will help him for that week and help him through the funneling content creation. Whose a spotlight this week on that artist? Maybe sharing the fabric song of this artist that you have. Maybe doing a cover of this artist's song." - Jose

This approach reimagines how artists might support each other by creating collective attention and resource flows, rather than competing individually.

Practical Resource Access

Artists identified specific material needs that Circles might help address:

> "In my case, I need strings to repair my guitar if needed. I know I need new instruments. I have a $100 guitar, and the guitar that I require to keep evolving as an artist is a $3,000 guitar at the minimum that I had researched that I loved, that I knew had the harmonics that I'm craving for when I play my guitar." - Jose

Other resource needs mentioned included:

- Audio equipment for performances
- Transportation to events
- Venue costs
- Instrument calibration

Impact Concerts & Education

Jose described his hybrid music-education events:

> "Not only sharing live music, but actually sharing the synthesis of information about Web3 to the average Joe and not the developer. So, the technical side of PEPS, but actually information that I, as a musician, was able to digest till a point that I can try with everybody. That was my idea: music and working and education." - Jose

This model uses artistic expression as a vehicle for education and community building, suggesting Circles could support work that crosses traditional category boundaries.

Questions & Tensions

Artists raised several questions about this potential use:

- How might small amounts of universal income aggregate to meaningful support?
- What relationship would this have to traditional music industry models?
- How could digital and physical communities be bridged effectively?

> "Authenticity is at the end, the core currency of the music itself. What you have these days in the industry is a lack of authenticity and even the encouragement and rewarding of the use of certain addictive substances into your songs. And the lack of bailís or, yeah, analogies to the natural world." - Jose

Community Care & Contribution

Many participants were drawn to Circles' potential to acknowledge care work and community contributions that typically go unrecognized financially.

Balancing Tokenization & Intrinsic Value

Delos articulated a key tension around tokenizing acts of care:

> "Maybe it's something going in the opposite direction. Instead of trying to financialize it in some sense, it doesn't hold some actual value. This token acts of love and care. I don't know how I feel about that." - Delos

This prompted thoughtful discussion about which types of care work might benefit from recognition versus which should remain outside token economies:

> "There are acts of care that we perform that aren't necessarily gestures of appreciation. Sometimes they're just things we need to do in our community. A neighbor who's disabled, so the people around me, I'll pitch in a little bit of help now and then." - rathermercurial

Examples of care work discussed included:

- Supporting elderly or disabled community members
- Environmental regeneration work
- Community organizing and moderation
- Knowledge sharing and education

Enhancing Existing Exchange Systems

Jose described existing barter systems in Venezuela that Circles might complement:

> "If I give guitar lessons instead of charging for free for the people that cannot pay, that is mostly everybody. They cannot pay $5 for a class. I told them to bring me a product of the essential food basket. So they brought me 1kg of flour." - Jose

This suggests Circles could build upon and enhance existing non-monetary exchange systems while maintaining their community-oriented nature.

Frictionless Micro-Recognition

Participants showed particular enthusiasm for lightweight ways to acknowledge value within existing community spaces.

"Circle for Your Thoughts"

Charlie proposed a tipping model for valuable content and contributions:

> "If someone makes a really long post or if I'm in Leftist Theory and someone shares a video that just really opens my mind and teaches me, I would definitely want to send them some Circles." - Charlie

This concept resonated with several participants who saw potential for creating simple recognition systems for knowledge sharing and meaningful contributions.

Community Space Integration

Several specific ideas emerged for integrating with community spaces like Discord:

> "Some kind of Discord that can move those circles around with just reacting to a message would make a lot of sense rather than some of these wallets that are more oriented towards Lisk, like a cold wallet. Not that they shouldn't be secure, but just... That's less important if the money's flying in and out." - Charlie

Participants imagined:

- Using emoji reactions to trigger Circle transactions
- Creating automated recommendation systems for tipping
- Making micro-recognition as frictionless as possible

Collaborative Content Creation

Jose proposed writing circles where members create content and share rewards:

> "We do a writing circle where each fifteen days we will put out all the new stuff that we passed through the week. And we started earning tokens on the high level because we started sending that privileged information that we have as natives to the average Joe." - Jose

This idea connects content creation with resource sharing in a collaborative model that could potentially create sustainable information commons.

Concerns & Questions

Value Translation

A significant concern expressed by multiple participants was how Circles value would translate to real-world purchasing power:

> "Even though it's technically only worth this much if we're trading amongst each other, somehow there would just be an agreed-on higher value. Otherwise, it just... I don't know how it would bridge into the real world." - Charlie

Participants wondered:

- How would small amounts of universal income (~$7/month) create meaningful impact?
- What mechanisms might encourage broader acceptance of Circles?
- How would communities determine appropriate valuations?

Boundaries of Tokenization

Several participants raised questions about which aspects of human relationships benefit from tokenization:

> "A token of appreciation could be a good gesture or another human relationship rather than just making another coin out of it. I feel we need to see where that line is with something like that." - Delos

This reflected deeper considerations about how financialization affects different types of relationships and contributions.

Technical Complexity

While excited about the possibilities, participants acknowledged barriers to adoption:

- How to explain the web of trust concept to new users
- Technical hurdles to seamless integrations
- Knowledge gaps that might limit community adoption

> "The hard part is that we have to start these conversations in those communities. Sometimes it's hard to get over knowledge gaps and get people inspired about using alternatives." - rathermercurial

Excitement & Interest Areas

Several areas generated particular enthusiasm among participants:

Alternative Value Expression

The ability to express different types of value beyond financial worth excited many participants:

> "I love the ideas of how a circle can mean many things for many different groups of people. It's a thing that is very unimaginable for me, right? When we talk about the currencies of money in our contemporary world, the dollar means dollar. It did not mean the same thing to at least in the traditional financial system." - Kin

Anti-Hoarding Mechanisms

Several participants were intrigued by Circles' design against wealth accumulation:

> "I love the ideas of anti hoarding as well. We'd love to have the kinds of like, you know, system in real life. We'll love to see how it's work and how it's like, you know, change the way we think about values, about moneyies, about currency." - Kin

Different Currency Dynamics

Charlie expressed excitement about experimenting with different currency dynamics:

> "The Bitcoin world is all about the hoarding, and so for this to incentivize... I wonder what will come out of that because people will be actively looking for ways to spend the circles and get... So, I think some kind of economy would emerge." - Charlie

Genuine Use Cases

Many participants appreciated the potential for real-world application:

> "This is just a beautiful, aurily, even this circles project, to truly be made into an actual practical experiment. Yeah, I just love that." - Charlie

Conclusion

The brainstorming sessions revealed a community excited about Circles' potential to create new ways of recognizing value, connecting communities, and supporting work that traditional economies often overlook. While practical questions remain about implementation and real-world impact, participants

showed genuine enthusiasm for experimenting with alternative currency systems that align more closely with community values.

The most compelling aspects that emerged were:

1. The ability to collectively determine value within communities rather than accept externally imposed valuations
2. The potential to recognize contributions that currently fall outside economic frameworks, particularly artistic and care work
3. The creation of bridges between global communities through intercultural exchange
4. The ability to express different types of value and appreciation in more nuanced ways
5. Creating sustainable support systems for artists and creators beyond traditional funding models

These themes provide a foundation for understanding what community members find most exciting about Circles and how they envision it might enhance their existing relationships and activities.